FINISH THE IDIOM

129 ENGLISH IDIOMS
MEANING AND EXAMPLE

IDIOMS 98

1 **Actions speak louder than words**
What you do matters more than what you say.
He promises a lot, but actions speak louder than words.

2 **Back to square one**
Back to the beginning after a failure.
The client rejected the design, so it's back to square one.

3 **The ball is in your court**
It is your decision now.
I've made my offer, so the ball is in your court.

4 **Bark up the wrong tree**
Follow completely the wrong idea.
If you think I took it, you're barking up the wrong tree.

5 **Be snowed under**
Have far too much work.
She's snowed under with marking.

6 **Be up in the air**
Still uncertain, not decided.
The date is up in the air until he answers.

7 **Beat around the bush**
Avoid saying what you really mean.
Stop beating around the bush and tell me the price.

8 **The bee's knees**
The very best thing there is.
She thinks that cafe is the bee's knees.

9 **Beggars can't be choosers**
If you have no choice, you take what you are given.
It's a tiny flat, but beggars can't be choosers.

10 **Bend over backwards**
Try extremely hard to help someone.
She bent over backwards to get us a table.

11 **The best of both worlds**
A situation where you get the advantages of two things.
Working two days at home is the best of both worlds.

12 **Better late than never**
Doing something late is better than not doing it.
He apologised after a year, but better late than never.

13 **Better safe than sorry**
It is wiser to be careful than to take a risk.
Take an umbrella, better safe than sorry.

14 **Bite the bullet**
Accept something unpleasant and get on with it.
We bit the bullet and told him the truth.

15 **A blessing in disguise**
Something that seems bad at first but turns out to be good.
Losing that job was a blessing in disguise.

16 **Break a leg**
Good luck, said to a performer.
Break a leg at the audition.

17 **Burn the midnight oil**
Work very late into the night.
I burned the midnight oil to finish the report.

18 **Butterflies in your stomach**
Nervous excitement before something.
I had butterflies in my stomach before the speech.

19 **Call it a day**
Stop working on something for now.
At six o'clock we called it a day.

20 **Cost an arm and a leg**
Be very expensive.
Parking at the airport costs an arm and a leg.

21 **A couch potato**
Someone who sits in front of the TV all day.
He's a couch potato at the weekend.

22 **Cut corners**
Do something cheaply or quickly and badly.
Don't cut corners on the safety checks.

23 **Cut to the chase**
Get to the important part.
Let's cut to the chase, how much do you want?

24 **The devil is in the detail**
The small details are where the real problems are.
The contract looks fine, but the devil is in the detail.

25 **Don't count your chickens before they hatch**
Don't rely on something good until it has actually happened.
You haven't signed yet, so don't count your chickens.

26 **Don't put all your eggs in one basket**
Don't risk everything on one plan.
Apply to three universities, don't put all your eggs in one basket.

27 **A double-edged sword**
Something with a good side and a bad side.
Working from home is a double-edged sword.

28 **The early bird catches the worm**
The person who acts first gets the advantage.
Tickets go fast, so the early bird catches the worm.

29 **Easier said than done**
It sounds simple but it is hard in practice.
Just stop worrying? Easier said than done.

30 **The elephant in the room**
An obvious problem that nobody wants to talk about.
Nobody mentioned the money, the elephant in the room.

31 **Every cloud has a silver lining**
Every bad situation has something good in it.
The flight was cancelled, but every cloud has a silver lining, we got a free hotel.

32 **Get cold feet**
Become too nervous to do something you planned.
I got cold feet and cancelled the interview.

33 **Get the hang of something**
Learn how to do something after a bit of practice.
She got the hang of the software in a day.

34 **Get your act together**
Start organising yourself and behaving properly.
If he doesn't get his act together, he'll fail.

35 **Go bananas**
Get wildly excited or very angry.
My dad went bananas when he saw the bill.

36 **Go down a rabbit hole**
Get lost in something complicated for a long time.
I went down a rabbit hole reading about volcanoes.

37 **Go pear-shaped**
Go badly wrong.
The whole trip went pear-shaped on day two.

38 **Go with the flow**
Accept the situation and do what others are doing.
There's no plan tonight, we'll just go with the flow.

39 **The grass is always greener on the other side**
Other people's situations always look better than yours.
She misses her old job, but the grass is always greener.

40 **A grey area**
A situation where the rules are not clear.
Working from another country is a grey area.

41 **Have a chip on your shoulder**
Stay angry about something unfair that happened to you.
He's had a chip on his shoulder since they passed him over.

42 **Have a lot on your plate**
Have a lot of work or problems to deal with.
He has a lot on his plate this month.

43 **Have bigger fish to fry**
Have more important things to deal with.
He won't mind, he's got bigger fish to fry.

44 **Have second thoughts**
Start to doubt a decision you made.
I'm having second thoughts about the flat.

45 **Have your head in the clouds**
Dreaming instead of dealing with real life.
He's lovely, but his head is always in the clouds.

46 **Hit the ground running**
Start something fast and well.
She hit the ground running in the new job.

47 **Hit the nail on the head**
Say exactly the right thing about a problem.
You've hit the nail on the head, it's a money problem.

48 **Hit the sack**
Go to bed.
Hit the sack early, we leave at six.

49 **In the long run**
Over a long period of time in the future.
In the long run, honesty is cheaper.

50 **In two minds**
Undecided about something.
She's in two minds about selling the flat.

51 **It takes two to tango**
Both people are responsible, not just one.
Don't blame her alone, it takes two to tango.

52 **Jump on the bandwagon**
Join something only because it has become popular.
Everyone jumped on the padel bandwagon last year.

53 **Kick the bucket**
Die, or stop working, said jokingly.
My phone kicked the bucket last night.

54 **The last straw**
The final small thing you can take.
The broken promise was the last straw for her.

55 **Let the cat out of the bag**
Give away a secret by accident.
He let the cat out of the bag about the party.

56 **Make ends meet**
Earn just enough money to pay for what you need.
With two kids, they're struggling to make ends meet.

57 **Miss the boat**
Lose a chance because you were too slow.
They missed the boat on the cheap tickets.

58 **No pain, no gain**
You have to suffer a little to get results.
My legs are killing me, but no pain, no gain.

59 **Not my cup of tea**
Not something you enjoy.
Horror films are not my cup of tea.

60 **Not the sharpest tool in the shed**
Not very clever, said kindly.
Lovely lad, just not the sharpest tool in the shed.

61 **Off the top of my head**
Without checking or thinking carefully.
Off the top of my head, I'd say about forty people came.

62 **On the fence**
Unable to decide between two sides.
Half the class is on the fence about the trip.

63 **On the same page**
In agreement, understanding things the same way.
The two teams were finally on the same page.

64 **On the tip of my tongue**
You almost remember a word but can't quite say it.
The word was on the tip of her tongue all evening.

65 **Once in a blue moon**
Very rarely.
He cooks once in a blue moon, and then it is beans on toast.

66 **Out of sight, out of mind**
You forget about things you cannot see.
Out of sight, out of mind works for my phone too.

67 **Out of the blue**
Suddenly and unexpectedly.
The email arrived completely out of the blue.

68 **Over the moon**
Absolutely delighted.
She was over the moon with the result.

69 **A pain in the neck**
Something or someone annoying.
Parking round here is a pain in the neck.

70 **A piece of cake**
Very easy.
For her, parallel parking is a piece of cake.

71 **Play it by ear**
Decide as you go, without a fixed plan.
Let's play it by ear and see who turns up.

72 **Practice makes perfect**
You improve at something by doing it repeatedly.
Keep speaking every day, practice makes perfect.

73 **Pull out all the stops**
Make every possible effort.
They pulled out all the stops for the wedding.

74 **Pull someone's leg**
Joke with someone by telling them something untrue.
She was pulling your leg about the fine.

75 **Put your foot in it**
Say something embarrassing or tactless by accident.
I asked about his wife, then really put my foot in it.

76 **Raining cats and dogs**
Raining extremely hard.
Take a coat, it's raining cats and dogs.

77 **A red herring**
A detail that leads you away from the truth.
That whole detail was a red herring.

78 **Ring a bell**
Sound familiar.
Does the title ring a bell?

79 **Saved by the bell**
Rescued at the very last second.
The phone rang and I was saved by the bell.

80 **A slippery slope**
A small bad step that leads to much worse things.
Lending him money is a slippery slope.

81 **Spill the beans**
Tell a secret.
He spilled the beans about the surprise.

82 **Steal someone's thunder**
Take the attention that should have been theirs.
She announced it first and stole his thunder.

83 **Stick to your guns**
Refuse to change your opinion or decision.
They pushed him hard, but he stuck to his guns.

84 **A storm in a teacup**
A lot of fuss about something unimportant.
The whole argument was a storm in a teacup.

85 **Take a rain check**
Say no for now but yes another time.
I'll take a rain check on dinner, I'm exhausted.

86 **Take it with a pinch of salt**
Don't believe it completely.
He exaggerates, so take it with a pinch of salt.

87 **There's no use crying over spilt milk**
There is no point being upset about something you can't change.
The car's sold now, no use crying over spilt milk.

88 **Through thick and thin**
In good times and bad.
They have stayed together through thick and thin.

89 **Throw in the towel**
Give up.
Don't throw in the towel this close to the end.

90 **Throw someone under the bus**
Blame someone else to save yourself.
He threw his own team under the bus in the meeting.

91 **The tip of the iceberg**
The small visible part of a much bigger problem.
Those complaints are just the tip of the iceberg.

92 **Touch wood**
Said to avoid bad luck after talking about good luck.
Touch wood, the car has never let me down.

93 **Under the weather**
Slightly ill.
I'm a little under the weather today.

94 **When in Rome, do as the Romans do**
Follow the local customs when you are somewhere new.
They eat at ten here, so when in Rome, do as the Romans do.

95 **When it rains, it pours**
Bad things tend to happen all at once.
The boiler broke, then the car died. When it rains, it pours.

96 **When pigs fly**
Never going to happen.
They'll apologise when pigs fly.

97 **You can't have your cake and eat it**
You can't have two good things that don't go together.
You want the money and the free time? You can't have your cake and eat it.

98 **You reap what you sow**
You get the results of your own actions.
He was rude to everyone for years, and you reap what you sow.

SIMILES 31

1 **Like a broken record**
Saying the same thing over and over.
I sound like a broken record, but please lock the door.

2 **Like a bull in a china shop**
Clumsy and careless with delicate things.
He came in like a bull in a china shop.

3 **Like a deer in the headlights**
Frozen, with no idea what to do.
When they asked him a question he looked like a deer in the headlights.

4 **Like a fish out of water**
Uncomfortable somewhere new or unfamiliar.
At my first rugby match I felt like a fish out of water.

5 **As blind as a bat**
Can hardly see anything.
Without my glasses I'm as blind as a bat.

6 **As busy as a bee**
Working non-stop.
He's been as busy as a bee since the baby arrived.

7 **As clear as mud**
Not clear at all.
His explanation was as clear as mud.

8 **As cool as a cucumber**
Completely calm when other people would panic.
She was as cool as a cucumber in the interview.

9 **As dry as a bone**
Completely dry.
The garden is as dry as a bone.

10 **As easy as pie**
Very easy once you know how.
After the second time it's as easy as pie.

11 **Eat like a horse**
Eat a huge amount.
He's skinny, but he eats like a horse.

12 **Fight like cat and dog**
Argue constantly.
Those two fight like cat and dog, then go for coffee.

13 **As fit as a fiddle**
In excellent health.
At seventy he's still as fit as a fiddle.

14 **Go down like a lead balloon**
Be received really badly.
My joke went down like a lead balloon.

15 **As good as gold**
Very well behaved.
He sat as good as gold through the concert.

16 **As happy as Larry**
Perfectly content with very little.
Give him a sandwich and he's as happy as Larry.

17 **Like herding cats**
Impossible to organise.
Teaching them on a Friday is like herding cats.

18 **As light as a feather**
Weighing almost nothing.
Pick it up, it's as light as a feather.

19 **As mad as a hatter**
Completely crazy, in a harmless funny way.
Her uncle is as mad as a hatter and we love him for it.

20 **As old as the hills**
Extremely old, and everyone has heard it before.
That joke is as old as the hills.

21 **As quiet as a mouse**
Making no sound at all.
She sat as quiet as a mouse at the back.

22 **As right as rain**
Perfectly fine again after feeling bad.
A cup of tea and I'll be as right as rain.

23 **Run around like a headless chicken**
Rush about in a panic with no plan.
He spent the morning running around like a headless chicken.

24 **As sick as a dog**
Very ill indeed.
I was as sick as a dog all weekend.

25 **Sleep like a log**
Sleep deeply and never move.
I walked all day and slept like a log.

26 **Spread like wildfire**
Travel incredibly fast, usually news.
The rumour spread like wildfire.

27 **As stubborn as a mule**
Refusing to change your mind.
Don't argue with him, he's as stubborn as a mule.

28 **Like talking to a brick wall**
A completely pointless conversation.
Asking him to listen is like talking to a brick wall.

29 **Like two peas in a pod**
Two people who are very alike.
Those two are like two peas in a pod.

30 **Like watching paint dry**
Unbelievably boring.
That meeting was like watching paint dry.

31 **As white as a sheet**
Pale with shock or fear.
She read the message and went as white as a sheet.